the events of 13 December, and the possible part played in them by the ‘deep state’ in India, into a kind of oblivion—a black hole of judicially mandated and media-packaged silence from which nothing can be recovered for posterity. With Afzal’s death, the possibility of concrete evidence for alternative explanations behind the events of that day will die. We will never know who or what entity actually masterminded the shootout in the Parliament that almost provoked a nuclear war and ensured the legislation of the infamous and now repealed Prevention of Terrorism Act (POTA) by the then BJP-led NDA ruling alliance. If the sentence is carried out, we will never know how much the shadowy senior echelons of the intelligence community in India, or the then Home Minister and Deputy Prime Minister L.K. Advani, or the then Defence Minister George Fernandes, or the then Prime Minister A.B. Vajpayee knew about the fact that a medical and surgical equipment salesman and surrendered JKLF militant called Mohammad Afzal Guru was being ‘cultivated’ through torture, threats and extortion by STF personnel and serving military and para-military officers. We will never know as to whether or not this ‘cultivation’ led up to the processes that included his being instructed to take a man called Mohammad to Delhi, who eventually turned up as the body of a slain terrorist outside the Indian Parliament in Delhi on 13 December. If Afzal dies, the deep state in India will just get a few fathoms deeper, and many uncomfortable secrets will die in its depths.

As I write this, I am sitting in faraway London, looking at pictures of Andamanese skulls, composite photographs of prisoners in British prisons and fingerprint impressions of convicts, taken in unnamed colonial prisons in nineteenth-century India. Sometimes I do this in two rooms scattered on the campus of the University College of London that houses the remains of what was once founded as the National Eugenics Laboratory by Francis Galton. Galton championed the idea that all social problems could be solved by lessons learnt through indexing, recording and measuring bodies and minds. The truths he sought to legislate, about innate criminality and intrinsic genius, about racial characteristics and inherited traits, were to be made concrete by measuring heads and deducing patterns from accumulated fingerprint impressions. In a series of haunting photographs, Galton produces what he calls ‘photo-composites’—anthropometric images obtained by layering portraits on to each other so that the features blend in to create a composite face. A face that takes something from all the faces that go into it. So you have the average criminal, the average lunatic, the average East End Jew, the